

Kosovo



Once part of the former Yugoslav state, Kosovo seceded from Serbia in 2008. International recognition, mainly from Western countries, is strongly opposed by Serbia and Russia.



GEOGRAPHY

Landlocked and mountainous, with two plains in the east and west.



CLIMATE

Continental, with warm, sunny summers and cold, snowy winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The balance of Albanians to Serbs in Kosovo has changed dramatically over centuries, both groups suffering interethnic violence at various times. Attacks against Albanians in the late 1990s caused a million to flee. After NATO stepped in, many Serbs left: Albanians now form a 92% majority. Most Albanians are Muslim. Serbs dominate three northern provinces, which have threatened to secede.



INSIGHT: *The UN administered Kosovo in 1999–2008 after NATO intervention to stop Serb ethnic cleansing*



THE ECONOMY

One of the two poorest countries in Europe. Aid and remittances cover a large trade deficit. Organized crime: smuggling of fuel, cigarettes, and cement. Uncertain status deters foreign investors. High unemployment. Use of euro has kept inflation low. Lignite deposits. Inefficient agriculture.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Kosovo

DATE OF FORMATION: 2008

CAPITAL: Pristina

POPULATION: 2.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 4212 sq. miles
(10,908 sq. km)

DENSITY: 499 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Albanian*, Serbian*, Bosniak, Gorani, Roma, Turkish

RELIGIONS: Muslim 92%, Roman Catholic 4%, Orthodox Christian 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Albanian 92%, Serb 4%, Bosniak and Gorani 2%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents